

Readings

Matthew 5:38 -48

Here's another old saying that deserves a second look, "Eye for eye, tooth for tooth." Is that going to get us anywhere? Here's what I propose. "Don't hit back at all." If someone strikes you, stand there and take it. If someone drags you into court and sues for the shirt off your back, giftwrap your best coat and make a present of it. And if someone take unfair advantage of you, use the occasion to practice the servant life. No more tit-for-tat stuff. Live generously.

You're familiar with the old written law, "Love your friend," and its unwritten companion, "Hate your enemy." I'm challenging that. I'm telling you to love your enemies. Let them bring out the best in you, not the worst. When someone gives you a hard time, respond with the energies of prayer, for then you are working out of your true selves, your God-created selves. This is what God does. God gives the best – the sun to warm and the rain to nourish – to everyone, regardless, the good and bad, the nice and nasty. If all you do is love the loveable, do you expect a bonus? Anybody can do that. If you simply say hello to those who greet you, do you expect a medal? Any run-of-the-mill sinner does that.

In a word, what I'm saying is, *Grow up*. You're kingdom subjects. Now live like it. Live out your God-created identity. Live generously and graciously toward others, the way God lives toward you.

(The Message Remix – Eugene H. Peterson)

Michael Leunig – adapted (Australian artist, cartoonist and poet)

Spirit of Truth, help us to find our confession;
The truth within us which is hidden from our mind;
The beauty or the ugliness we see elsewhere
But never in ourselves;
The stowaway which has been smuggled
Into the dark side of the heart,
Which puts the heart off balance and causes it pain,
Which wearies and confuses us,

Which tips us in false directions and inclines us to destruction,
The load which is not carried squarely
Because it is carried in ignorance.
Spirit of Life, help us to find our confession.
Help us across the boundary of our understanding.
Lead us into the darkness that we may find what lies concealed;
That we may confess it towards the light;
That we may carry our truth in the center of our heart;
That we may carry our burdens wisely
And bring harmony into our life and our world. Amen.

Seeing the Positive in Negative People

You know, I like to think of myself as a calm, easy to get along with, spiritual type person. I take pride in the fact that I can interact well with all sorts of folks. However, well, if the truth be known, there are just some people who drive me nuts!

I'm sure you know what I'm talking about. There are some people who are just plain difficult folks. They are hard to get along with. They are socially inept. They are loud and obnoxious and opinionated. And worst of all, they don't seem to notice all this!

In addition to these troublesome people, there are also things some people do which tick me off! They make me so mad. These are the things that I would call my "pet peeves." Things like: cutting me off in traffic or not driving fast enough in the left lane. When my neighbors park their vehicles in front of my house when there is plenty of room in front of their own yards. When friends do not keep their promises. When beautiful, thin, and young women get praise for mediocre work and I am ignored even when I do something outstanding. When someone brings 30 items to the express checkout lane which clearly is for purchases of only 12 items.

Most of these are piddly little things, but they do irritate me to no end.

And I know I am not the only one here who feels this way. In a moment, I'm going to ask you to share about your pet peeves and difficult people. But first, let me give you a couple of ground rules. Since we are a community here, it is more than likely that there are folks within these very walls who grate on your nerves. (What a surprise!) I am going to ask that you share only general actions or characteristics. This is not the time to hint or point at another person or single them out. That ultimately will not fit with the spiritual texture of this sermon.

So, please vent, both the silly and the serious, only do so without embarrassing any one person.

And I will start us off. I really have to work hard to remember my compassion when I'm with people who are invested in keeping a

"victim" mentality. I don't have much patience for people who are into conspiracy theories. They aren't interested in a reasoned discussion and when I disagree with their ideas and I'm deemed an unenlightened and ignorant dupe.

Now, tell us briefly about the people who are like finger nails on a chalk board to you.

The next question I have for you is this: What do you do when you are faced with these kinds of people? You don't have to answer out loud, but do pay attention to your responses.

I may yell at them while I'm in my car. Or bite my tongue and avoid them. Or complain about them to a sympathetic ear. What do you do when these people or their actions get to you?

And finally, my last question to you is this: What do you wish would happen? Generally, I wish they'd stop doing whatever it is they are doing. Or, I wish they would get caught, or that something would make them change. What do you find yourself wishing when you encounter these difficulties?

Many of us might also say - we wish they would just go away. Yet... I want to suggest to you that actually, these cantankerous folks, these social misfits, these thoughtless people, these idiots.... are immensely valuable to us.

Listen to these words from Buddhist teaching.

When you meet a person (being) of bad nature,
pressed by violent sins and sufferings,
do not turn away,
but treat this person as a precious treasure rare to find.

Doesn't that seem all backward? Precious treasure? That's a stretch! Often it is hard enough to look past all the flaws and faults of such a person to see the inherent worth and dignity of such an individual. Yet now I'm telling you that these difficult, negative people are both necessary and terribly valuable.

In truth, we can gain more from the folks who rub us the wrong way than we can from the good natured, reasonable, soft-spoken people. We learn from these problem people and from the actions that provoke us. They are indeed valuable because they teach us hard

lessons.

One story illustrates how priceless these negative people really are.

In the spiritual community that G.I. Gurdjieff led in France, an old man lived there who was the personification of difficulty - irritable, messy, fighting with everyone, and unwilling to clean up or help at all. No one got along with him. Finally, after many frustrating months of trying to stay with the group, the old man left for Paris. Gurdjieff followed him and tried to convince him to return, but it had been too hard, and the man said no. At last, Gurdjieff offered the man a very big monthly stipend if he returned. How could he refuse? When he returned everyone was aghast, and on hearing that he was being paid (while they were being charged a lot to be there), the community was up in arms. Gurdjieff called them together and after hearing their complaints laughed and explained: "This man is like yeast for bread." He said, "Without him here you would never really learn about anger, irritability, patience, and compassion. That is why you pay me, and why I hire him."

There is an old spiritual maxim that states - When someone or something disturbs our serenity, we must look inside to discover the real cause. Negative, disruptive, disturbing people can make us confront the negative, disruptive, and disturbing parts of ourselves. We come face to face with our shadow side: anger, self-pity, unrealistic expectations, intolerance, our biased definitions of who is attractive and beautiful and who is repulsive and ugly, envy, greed, aggression, fears, irritability, judgmentalism, pride, the "isms" - racism, sexism, ageism, heterosexism, classism, etc., hostility, self-righteousness.

We learn from conflict. Outward conflict, as uncomfortable as it is for most of us, there are gems here. Perhaps you can think of a time you learned something about yourself through conflict. Maybe you learned to see another person's perspective and appreciate what before you had thought was all wrong.

Let me state here, however, that you should not suffer abuse for the sake of learning these lessons. For some, just learning how to

engage in honest confrontation is a huge challenge.

Then there's inward conflict, the internal dispute. Others may not even know you are upset, but you are seething inside, biting your tongue or counting to ten. You may be working to keep yourself in check. Or you may be working up the courage to say what must be said.

We learn about our self-control. How to select our battles, what and whom we can influence and what and whom we can't change.

A disclaimer here, be aware that while encountering contrary people, you may realize great spiritual lessons and you may come to discover aspects of yourself you would otherwise not see.

This is not in any way a suggestion that you become a doormat or suffer abuse. Sometimes the biggest lessons are in learning to confront another in love.

Well, now that you have heard that there is much good available to you through clashing with difficult people, I'd also like to tell you about some spiritual ways to deal with these matters - once you have decided you are tired of learning the lessons and annoyed with the pain.

There is, of course, non-resistance. Sometimes we just take what is dished out. Earlier I read to you Matthew 5:38-42. It suggests we turn the other cheek.

Resistance makes a bad situation exhausting. There is the Buddhist spiritual equation: Pain multiplies by resistance equals suffering,

This does not mean we should do nothing in the face of injustice and wrong-doing. But an attitude of resistance makes matters worse. Many of our UU heroes are women and men who have intentionally used non-resistance as a tactic in addressing social ills.

Acceptance is another approach. This does not mean we have to like something - we may never like it. But we can accept it. We admit the truth of its reality. We can acknowledge the way things are. AA's Big Book states:

"Acceptance is the answer to all my problems today. When I am disturbed, it is because I find some person, place, thing, or situation - some fact of my life - unacceptable to me, and I can find no serenity

until I accept that person, place, thing, or situation as being exactly the way it is supposed to be at this moment." (p. 449)

Sometimes we have to remind ourselves that the world is not formed just to suit us and our preferences. We must accept that life doesn't need our permission to be as it is. Acceptance is often the best beginning when dealing with people that we don't like.

In addition to non-resistance and acceptance, we can pray or send good energy. As a minister and spiritual counselor, I would assign homework to patients, parishioners and clients. If a particular individual is testing your nerves and patience - pray for her or him (Don't pray that God should smite them!) but pray for them for at least two weeks. Hold them in the light, send positive thoughts their way. Pray for that person what you would like for yourself. If you are earnest about this, your attitude toward that person will usually be different within two weeks and you will be less agitated.

We can approach difficult people with mindful compassion. We can separate the person from the behavior. Even in our language, we can compassionately remember that the difficult person is not their action. "Esmerelda is a whiner" is different from "Esmerelda whines, a lot!"

It is helpful to remember that behavior has some reason under. This is true even in cases of dementia. Perhaps addressing the underlying need may change the behavior. Or not. It can remind us of our common humanity.

Don't take the negative person's behavior personally. Understand that compassion does not remove consequences. I might need to set firm boundaries, apply disciplinary action as a manager, or distance myself from an individual. I can do any of these things with genuine compassion.

And finally, one way to deal with difficult people is through confrontation. To be truly effective, confrontation must not be a reaction. It must come from a centered, stable place. We must confront not in anger or rage, but in love. There is a terrific Buddhist Story:

A young female disciple undertook to develop the meditation on loving-kindness. Sitting in her small room, she would fill her heart

with loving-kindness for all beings, yet each day as she went to the bazaar to gather her food, she would find her loving-kindness sorely tested by one shopkeeper who would daily subject her to unwelcome caresses. One day she could stand no more and began to chase the shopkeeper down the road with her upraised umbrella. To her mortification she passed her teacher standing on the side of the road observing this spectacle. Shame-faced, she went to stand before him expecting to be rebuked for her anger.

"What you should do," her teacher kindly advised her, "is to fill your heart with loving-kindness, and with as much mindfulness as you can muster, hit this unruly fellow over the head with your umbrella."

Finding the positive from negative people and situations may require that we confront unjust circumstances and harmful actions. But we do it from a place of serenity and love.

As we conclude this sermon. I remind you that life is hard, and troublesome people try our patience. It is strenuous to keep our balance when dealing with these folks. The bad news is - no matter what, you will keep running into negative people. They are out there and they will find you!

The good news is, these contrary people are actually a precious treasure for you. You may not enjoy these encounters anymore after hearing this message, but my hope is, we will all better appreciate the gold hidden within very discouraging wrapping. And while we strive to remember the positive we can gain from negative people, let us also remember, to someone, somewhere we are their difficult treasure!

Amen and Amen